At home, Gertrude began talking of buying a house. The thought frightened me, for I felt I would be lost with lawns and gardens to take care of and with no landlord to turn to if something went wrong.

Nevertheless, Gertrude was right. We could afford a house now and we should have one for David's sake if not our own. We began a desultory search, but if looking for an apartment and working up the nerve to make a decision was hard, looking for and making a decision concerning houses was infinitely harder.

Everything we saw was either obviously too expensive or obviously not good enough.

The Puzzle of Life was showing unexpected signs of life again. Macmillan asked me for a book, and when I told them about my popular biochemistry, they invited me to show them a sample. I decided to

do a new version of the first chapter, doing it entirely my way and not as modified by Little, Brown pressure.

I finished Lucky Starr and the Pirates of the Asteroids on October 24, and took it in to Brad on October 28, when we three were in New York again.

I spent the evening with Horace, talking about the new robot novel, The Caves of Steel, for which Brad had agreed to let me have a contract.

On October 31, I visited my parents. They were buying another apartment house, which would make three houses that they owned, and they were trying to sell the candy store.

29

On November 4, 1952, the presidential election took place. Gertrude and I each voted for Stevenson, but it was a lost cause. At 5:45 p.m. I wrote in my diary, "Now I sit down and start listening to the Eisenhower landslide." Actually, I started viewing it, since, for the first time, I was watching an election on television.

By 8:25 p.m. it was all over and I watched only intermittently thereafter. It was no fun anyway. A computer, "Univac," was computing the results on the basis of initial returns and robbed the election of any suspense there might have been.